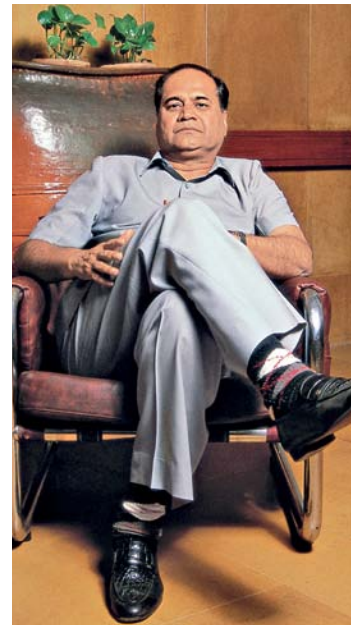
ing why he believed Indian governments weren't doing enough to protect domestic industry. Maruti Suzuki chairman R.C. Bhargava feels critics misunderstood Bajaj on this 'protectionist stand'. Being a nationalist, Bajaj wanted Indian industry to grow, but he was also a realist who recognised that Indian manufacturers were greatly disadvantaged compared to their foreign counterparts, says Bhargava. For all his calls for protectionism, Bajaj also knew how to make foreign partnerships work—Bajaj Auto had a rather successful run with Japan's Kawasaki for nearly three decades, starting in the 1990s. Bajaj also championed the cause of Indian industry at international forums for over four decades. Since 1979, he had been a leading light at the World Economic Forum in Davos, founded by his close friend Klaus Schwab, rarely missing a year at the event.

Bajaj was one of the few industrialists who saw their businesses thrive both during the licence raj and the open economy post the 1991 liberalisation. He started his journey with the Bajaj Group in 1965 and became managing director in 1972 after the demise of his father, Kamalnayan Bajaj. The Group had been set up by his grandfather Jamnalal Bajaj, a close associate of Mahatma Gandhi, in 1926. The Bajaj family was also closely involved with India's Independence movement. Rahul Bajaj loved to flaunt his family connections with the Nehru-Gandhi families and proudly said in many interviews that he was named by Jawaharlal Nehru.

It was under Rahul Bajaj that the group diversified into insurance, financial services and electrical products. The diversification into financial services was a game-changer, making the group the third-largest Indian family business, after those controlled by the Ambani and Adani families, with a market capitalisation (m-cap) of Rs 8.5 lakh crore as on February 11. The group, run by Bajaj, his sons, and his three cousins—Shekhar, Niraj and Madhur Bajaj—comprises 40 companies, employing 36,000 people worldwide. The group's listed companies had total standalone revenues of Rs 59,364 crore and standalone profits of Rs 9,123.8 crore in 2020-'21. Bajaj Finance, led by Rahul Bajaj's younger son Sanjiv, is the seventh-largest Indian company in terms of its m-cap (Rs 4.3 lakh crore), while Bajaj Finserv was ranked 20th with Rs 2.6 lakh crore as on February 15. A family division in 2007 saw the exit of Rahul's brother Shishir from the group, along with Shishir's son Kushagra Nayan Bajaj, moving on to run separate businesses that include Bajaj Hindusthan Sugar and Bajaj Energy. After passing the baton on to Rajiv and Sanjiv, Bajaj spent a lot of time travelling, often in his private jet, meeting people and sharing his views on various industry platforms at home and abroad.



PUSHPENDU CHAUDHRY

"Our soft power of civilisation and inherent tolerance of diversity have been around for some time. We have to now marry them with the hard economic power that the world today respects more than anything else"

Rahul Bajaj will perhaps be most remembered for the iconic Bajaj Chetak, a scooter modelled on Italian two-wheeler maker Piaggio's Vespa Sprint, which was a runaway success for several years. In 1989, when brands like Kinetic Honda and Vespa began snapping at its heels, Bajaj Auto went on to launch its famous 'Hamara Bajaj' campaign, conceived by ad agency Lintas. It is another matter that Bajaj had to cede to son Rajiv's decision to scrap scooters from Bajaj Auto's portfolio in 2009 to focus on motorcycles. Maybe his point was vindicated when a whole new generation of scooters led by Honda Activa began to find a big market again, forcing Rajiv to re-introduce the Chetak in an electric avatar in 2020.

Bajaj Auto's battles for market share with Hero MotorCorp are legendary. But for all his aggression in protecting his turf, Rahul Bajaj had an extremely soft corner for Brijmohan Lall Munjal, the late founder of rival Hero MotorCorp, whom he publicly referred to as his guru. "Over the years, we fought very fiercely in the marketplace, first with Hero Honda, then with Hero MotoCorp. There was no give and take. Yet, we remained very good friends," he said, when Munjal passed away in 2015. A Rajya Sabha member from 2006 to 2010, Bajaj stressed the need for an astute political leadership, a supportive business environment and a strong partnership between the government and business. "Our soft power of civilisation and inherent tolerance of diversity have been around for some time. We have to now marry them with the hard economic power that the world today respects more than anything else," he said at the India Today Conclave in 2005. Those words have a lot of relevance even in today's context. ■